'*Beta*, what guarantee is there in these troubled times? While we stand and talk, anyone could have gone anywhere.'

His suspicions confirmed, Rajeev rushed in and cordoned off the mosque. His tentative inquiry, 'Anyone there?' was met by a hail of gunfire. What should he do now? We were under strict instructions not to defile any place of worship. Additional troops were called in and sharpshooters were positioned at vantage points. Village elders were summoned to try and persuade the terrorists to surrender. They confirmed that Ghulam Mustafa Khan, a dreaded category 'A' terrorist hailing from the same village, was holed up inside. However, the mukdam and other elders were not able to convince them to surrender. Mustafa Khan's parents were summoned to try their luck. Mustafa's mother had tears streaming down her face. She knew that this script had only one ending. Mustafa once again refused to surrender. We had no choice but to match deed for deed, fire with fire. A few hours later, Mustafa and two of his accomplices lay dead inside the compound of the mosque, killed while trying to break through the cordon. Barely out of their teens, the three had chosen a path that had only brought death and destruction in its wake. And now, they were the victims. In the exchange of fire, Capt Bahuguna was critically injured and evacuated by helicopter to the 92 Base Hospital at Srinagar.

As we disengaged from the village, the villagers turned hostile. Egged on by Mustafa's father Razzaq Khan and his vociferous daughters, the crowd chanted anti-India and anti-Army slogans. Keeping our cool, we disengaged without any mishaps. But in our hearts lurked a little bitterness. We had done our job. Observed all the rules of civilized warfare. Even asked the terrorists to surrender so that their lives be spared. Suffered a casualty ourselves. Then why was there this outpouring of bitterness against us? During the post-operation

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